

STAGE SIX • COMMUNICATION: SPEAKING, READING & WRITING

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Six • Communication: Speaking, Reading & Writing

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Six involves more on-camera and on-the-spot moments than almost any other stage — recording yourself, impromptu speaking, role-playing conflict. This script leans especially heavily on Parts 3 and 4 as a result.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS and sessions, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get uncomfortable or stuck.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

"Welcome to Stage Six — Communication. This is the largest stage in the whole program, seventy FIRSTS across six sessions, and today we start with the most common channel of all: writing."

"Given how much ground we're covering today, I'll keep the framing for each FIRST brief — a few minutes each — and lean on your own real writing rather than hypothetical examples wherever we can."

Opening Session 2

"Last time was about the written word. Today is about the spoken one — scripting, delivering, and recording yourself, which for most people is genuinely the most uncomfortable part of this entire program."

"A heads-up before we start: several exercises today involve recording yourself on video or speaking with no preparation. That discomfort is normal, and it's also exactly the point — it's where the real learning happens."

Opening Session 3

"Today shifts from producing communication to receiving it — listening and reading well are just as much a communication skill as writing or speaking, even though they get talked about far less."

Opening Session 4

"Today is about communication between people, in real time — networking, interviews, facilitation, and the conversations most people actively avoid, like addressing conflict directly."

"Several of today's exercises work best as role-play. I'll pair you up deliberately rather than leaving it to chance — that's intentional, not random."

Opening Session 5

"Today turns the lens inward: how you give and receive feedback, and how you reflect honestly on your own communication, including things like public speaking anxiety that most people never actually examine closely."

Opening Session 6 (Stage Close)

"This is our final session for Stage Six, and it's about building systems — goals, tracking, note-taking, visual communication — that make everything from this stage sustainable going forward, not just a one-time push."

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST I1 → I2

"You've got the structure for a clear individual message. A meeting agenda is the same clarity principle applied to a whole conversation instead of just one email."

FIRST I8 → I9

"Your draft is down. Now, genuinely, step away from it for a few minutes before we edit — editing immediately after drafting is the single most common mistake in this FIRST."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Everything today was on the page. Next session, we take communication off the page entirely — into your actual voice, live, in the room."

FIRST I5 → I11

"You just watched yourself speak on video, which is uncomfortable but genuinely useful. Let's apply that same discipline to something you'll actually use often: your elevator pitch."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've spent two sessions on producing communication — writing and speaking. Today's about the other half: genuinely receiving it, through listening and reading."

Session 3 → Session 4

"You can now process what comes at you clearly. Today puts that together with speaking — real, live, back-and-forth conversation with other people."

FIRST I12 → I13

"You just practiced sustaining a genuine conversation. A mock interview is a specific, higher-stakes version of that same skill — sustained exchange under real pressure."

Session 4 → Session 5

"You've had a lot of real conversations today. Now let's turn to the conversations you have with yourself — reflecting honestly on how all of this is actually going."

FIRST I7 → I25

"You just practiced receiving feedback without getting defensive. Giving it well is the flip side of that same skill — and most people find it just as uncomfortable."

Session 5 → Session 6

"You've reflected deeply on where you stand. This final session is about building the systems that keep you improving after this program ends, not just during it."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

Someone is visibly nervous before a recording or impromptu exercise

“Everyone in this room feels some version of what you're feeling right now. The goal isn't a perfect take — it's just doing the real thing once, on purpose.”

A participant's writing exercise stays vague after multiple attempts

“Let's get concrete. What's the actual sentence you'd say if the reader were sitting right in front of you?” (Speaking the real ask aloud often unlocks a clearer written version.)

Someone dominates a group discussion or role-play

“Great point — let's make sure we hear from a couple of other people on this too.” Then explicitly invite a specific quieter participant by name.

A participant resists a role-play scenario as “too awkward”

“That awkwardness is a real signal — it usually means this is exactly the kind of scenario worth practicing before it happens for real.”

The room is reluctant to give honest peer feedback

“Vague, kind feedback doesn't actually help. Try this: one specific thing that worked, one specific thing you'd change. That's genuinely useful, and it's not a performance review.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS (or closely paired FIRSTS) where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or uncomfortable — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST I5 / I21

Public Speaking Recording / Voice Recording Review

FACILITATOR NOTE

Watching and hearing yourself is genuinely uncomfortable for nearly everyone. Never require participants to share the recording with the group — the value is entirely in their own private review.

FIRST I29

Impromptu Speaking Drill

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants will freeze completely on their first attempt. That's a normal, expected outcome, not a failure — reassure them explicitly and move on to the next person without dwelling on it.

FIRST I40

Reflection on Public Speaking Anxiety

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can surface genuine, sometimes significant anxiety for some participants. Keep the framing squarely on specific, manageable triggers rather than treating it as a deep psychological exploration — and know when to suggest a participant follow up with appropriate support beyond this session if their anxiety seems to go beyond typical public speaking nerves.

FIRST I42

Conflict Resolution Conversation

FACILITATOR NOTE

If role-playing with a real, current conflict (rather than a hypothetical), check in privately with both participants first — make sure they're both genuinely comfortable role-playing it in front of others, or offer a hypothetical scenario instead.